

AP

KEEPING AN EYE OUT
General Syed Asim Munir, the chief of Pakistan Army

nothing else is going right for the country and managed to capitalise on the mounting public anger at the crumbling economy, especially the rising cost of living.

Initially, Khan attempted to build a narrative that his ouster was a global conspiracy, led by the United States. After many months, and possibly after a strong reaction from the US, he backtracked on implicating the Americans and claimed the real villains were his local political rivals—primarily the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) and the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), which form the backbone of the PDM—and the (now retired) army chief Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa, who, he says, "stabbed me in the back".

Some of the anger against Khan among the ruling coalition members is because of the frustration of having to bear the brunt of the political fallout of his government's mismanagement of the economy. The Shehbaz Sharif-led PDM government fears that this will adversely affect its chances in the coming elections. But some of it is also due to a sense that justice should be done—Khan is seen to have come to power in 2018 not through a legitimate process but through elections rigged by the military establishment. And it is felt that he should not be the beneficiary of further support as a result of these discredited policies.

THE ROLE OF THE PAKISTAN ARMY

As far as the military establishment is concerned, while the new army chief Gen. Asim Munir has so far steadfastly refused to be overtly drawn into the political crisis, Khan has, on more than one occasion, expressed his frustration that the new chief is not willing to talk to him one-on-one and that the new military leadership is pursuing the same policies as the previous one, apparently against PTI or at least not overtly favouring it.

There is allegedly a bit of history to Khan's relationship with the new army chief that is probably making him and his party nervous. Gen. Munir was appointed chief of the Inter-Services Intelligence during Khan's tenure as prime minister but was surprisingly removed only seven months into a three-year tenure and replaced by Gen. Faiz Hameed, who was later accused of helping Khan with his political engineering. Although no reasons were given, some in Islamabad claimed that Gen. Munir was removed when he allegedly went to Khan with documentary evidence of his wife Bushra Bibi's involvement in corruption scandals. Gen. Munir has never spoken publicly about any of this, but it was an open secret that, on Gen. Bajwa's retirement, he would not be the PTI's preferred candidate, despite solid professional credentials and seniority.

THE ARMY BRASS IS WORRIED THAT KHAN'S ATTEMPTS TO KEEP PAKISTAN ON THE BRINK ARE AFFECTING GOVERNMENT EFFORTS TO SAVE THE ECONOMY FROM GOING INTO A MELTDOWN

The top brass must be concerned at the daily broadsides coming from Khan against his former benefactors. It's the first time that any mainstream politician has so directly been vocal about the army in such detail, emboldening his supporters to criticise army officers by name. Even more worrying for them must be how Khan's attempts to keep the country on the brink of political instability affect the efforts to pull it back from the edge of the economic precipice. The army must surely be unhappy with how Khan has targeted it, but is wary of taking overt action that might draw further ire from Khan's supporters. After the experience of the Khan "hybrid regime" years, it also does not want to be perceived